

INT. THE BEAR/KITCHEN

Carmy preps for dinner service in the kitchen. He's focused; the only thing he can see is the food he's preparing in front of him.

His RIGHT HAND starts to TREMBLE, but he pushes through.

CHOP. CHOP. CHOP. **FLASH.**

INT. THE BEAR/KITCHEN - DINING AREA

Suddenly, Carmy's serving a dish table-side. Again, all he can see is the food in front of him. Everything seems normal until he places the dishes in front of his customers and when we see that they're are ALL BEARS.

He stutters when he notices, but shrugs it off. He goes back into the kitchen quickly to ask what's going on.

INT. THE BEAR/KITCHEN - CONTINUOUS

The doors fly open and Carmy starts to talk, but the room is EMPTY.

He's befuddled, but not long before orders come flying in, and suddenly he's BACK TO COOKING on his own.

Now he's racing against the CLOCK--

TICKING, COUNTING DOWN, PRESSING HIM--

But he can't keep up. He's getting messy, slipping up, FALTERING.

His HAND is SHAKING UNCONTROLLABLY.

The CLOCK moves FASTER.

One of the "customers" BARGES into the kitchen. It SNARLS and SWIPES items off the counters, slowly APPROACHING.

Carmy tries to focus on the food, but the bear PUSHES him away from his station and BACKS him into the walk-in fridge.

INT. THE BEAR/FRIDGE - CONTINUOUS

The door shuts like a cage, and Carmy turns around to find a bear trapped inside with him.

For a moment he's frozen. Face to face with the creature.

There's RINGING in the distance.

Time's up.

And it POUNCES.

SMASH CUT TO:

INT. CARMY'S ROOM - SAME TIME

Carmy wakes up groggy, disoriented. He rubs his eyes and sits up to get a hold of himself.

He looks down at his hand - SHAKY.

He tries to GRAB IT, as if to MUFFLE IT, but it won't stop.

INT. THE BEAR/KITCHEN - MORNING

The crew trickles in one by one for the start of the day. Each person has less energy than the last. Everyone but Carmy, Richie, and Natalie is on the scene.

Sydney leads the pack, more disciplined than the rest, and heads for her locker where she exchanges her coat and backpack for her apron.

She notices the general slump everyone's in.

SYDNEY
Morning everyone.

EVERYONE
Morning chef.

SYDNEY
Anyone know where Carmy or Natalie is?

Right on cue, Natalie walks in late.

SYDNEY (CONT'D)
Nevermind.

NATALIE
Sorry, me and Pete just had a thing.

SYDNEY
Good thing or bad thing?

NATALIE
Pete thing.

Sydney raises her eyebrows, sarcastic, but understanding.

SYDNEY
I see.

NATALIE
Where's Carmy?

SYDNEY
I was going to ask you the same thing.

NATALIE
Try his phone?

Sydney sighs reluctantly, but pulls out her phone anyway.

Natalie gives a reassuring smile, and heads off to her office.

Sydney dials Carmy.

INT. CARMY'S APARTMENT/BEDROOM - SAME TIME

Carmy's phone lights up with the time. He sees the time for the first.

CARMY
Shit.

He answers.

CARMY (CONT'D)
(on the phone)
Yeah?

SYDNEY
Good morning to you too. Are you planning on joining us today any time soon?

CARMY
Uhh, can't- not feeling well. PTO.

SYDNEY
PTO?

CARMY
Just ask Natalie. Sorry.

He hangs up abruptly.

INT. THE BEAR/KITCHEN - SAME TIME

Sydney looks shocked at her phone. She gives a face that says "This Bitch".

She puts her phone away, frustrated, and at the same time --

Richie walks in with more energy than everyone else combined.

RICHIE

WOO! We got a great day ahead of us!

SYDNEY

Why are we yelling already?

RICHIE

This is it! This is the big time! Major leagues! Super-Bowl! The Fucking World Cup!!!

Natalie walks out to all the noise.

NATALIE

It is barely 8 in the morning, and I can understand my literal baby better than you, what are you saying?

RICHIE

I just made your today, because I got a critic for us.

Sydney's face turns to dread.

RICHIE (CONT'D)

You're welcome.

SYDNEY

No, we can't today.

RICHIE

Yes, today.

SYDNEY

Cancel it, we're short-staffed.

Richie takes a dramatic look around.

RICHIE

All I see is the face of this
restaurant
(he gestures to himself)
And a kitchen full of cooks.

SYDNEY

Carry's not coming in - ergo we
can't have a *critic* coming in.

RICHIE

No, you know what? He's one guy,
and we pulled off opening night,
just fine without him.

SYDNEY

That one guy is the head chef of
the kitchen, owner of the
restaurant, and best fucking cook
in Chicago.

RICHIE

I thought you wanted a chance to
prove you can do something great.
Well, here you go. The critic's
coming today, and you better be
ready.

NATALIE

Rich, lay off.

Richie walks off leaving Sydney to make a choice.

Natalie gives her a look, and she tries to avoid it.

Sydney takes a moment, and closes her eyes to accept what's
ahead, then she gets an idea.

She grabs a nearby knife, and walks over to Richie.

RICHIE

Woah, woah! We are not doing this
again!

Richie backs up, cautious, but she just hands it to him.

SYDNEY

Fine. You win, but you're going to
help with prep.

INT. CARMY'S APARTMENT/BEDROOM - SAME TIME

Carmy makes his way out of bed, and stumbles into his apartment.

INT. CARMY'S APARTMENT/LIVING ROOM - CONTINUOUS

Something like GREEN DAY'S "BRAIN STEW" plays over a small montage of Carmy cooking himself the crappiest breakfast you've ever seen.

Carmy BREAKS EGGS, shoves BREAD into a TOASTER, chops up a couple HOT DOGS, POURS EGG YOLK INTO A PAN.

CRACK! Egg shells SHATTER into the mix.

CARMY
Shit. Fuck.

Carmy tries to fish the pieces out, but he STRUGGLES with his hand UNSTABLE.

He finishes the dish by FRYING EGGS, and he grabs BURNED TOAST to plate.

The music carries into --

INT. THE BEAR/KITCHEN - SAME TIME

Ebraheim DICES TOMATOES and ONIONS, Tina FILETS FRESH SALMON, Marcus pours MILK into a BOWL and sets a TRAY OF PASTRIES into an oven.

Sydney walks around TASTING various cooks' ingredients as they all work at their own stations. Sweeps TIES HIS SHOES, Fak FIXES HIS HAIR. Richie CLEANS HIS SUIT using a lint roller.

Back to --

INT. CARMY'S APARTMENT/LIVING ROOM - SAME TIME

Carmy munches on a mess of food over a plastic plate while sitting on his couch.

His eyes glossed over, lost in his own thought.

INT. THE BEAR/DINING AREA - LUNCH TIME

Sweeps checks on a nearby table enjoying their meal.

SWEEPS
How's everything going guys?

They throw two thumbs up, their mouths too stuffed to speak.

SWEEPS (CONT'D)
Happy to hear it. I'll be around if
you need anything.

He smiles and turns away to check on the kitchen.

INT. THE BEAR/KITCHEN - SAME TIME

Tina mans a station where a PAN LIGHTS FIRE. She shakes it out, turns the heat down.

EBRAHEIM
You're making it feel like a
microwave in here.

TINA
How would you fit in a microwave?

EBRAHEIM
That's not the point. It feels like
you're trying to cook us in here.

SYDNEY (O.S.)
Let's keep the heat down.

TINA
Heard, chef!

EBRAHEIM
Exactly.

Tina gives him a side eye.

Sweeps walks in and heads to Sydney.

SWEEPS
Customers are doing good out there.
How's the lunch rush in here?

SYDNEY
It's a little --

Marcus runs past them holding another tray of pastries.

MARCUS
BEHIND!

SYDNEY

Hectic. But I think I got it under control.

SWEEPS

Anything else I can do to help?

SYDNEY

Not right now. You're doing great balancing out Richie.

SWEEPS

(chuckles)

I do my best.

Richie joins in.

RICHIE

What'd I miss?

SYDNEY

(sarcastic)

Nothing, we were debating who's taller.

RICHIE

Me.

SYDNEY

I don't know. It's 2 to 1 over here.

SWEEPS

When's that critic gonna arrive?

RICHIE

He's coming in right now.

SYDNEY

Right now right now?

RICHIE

I'm opening the door for him any minute.

SYDNEY

No, let Natalie --

RICHIE

Relax. I got this. You do your thing, and I'll do mine.

Richie gives her an expecting look, then heads off.

SWEEPS

You sure you don't need anything?

SYDNEY

Nope. I got this.

Sydney puts what she's doing down, and turns to address the kitchen.

SYDNEY (CONT'D)

Listen up, everyone! I was just informed that our critic will be seated any minute. Let's give them our best shift, yes?

EVERYONE

Yes, chef!

INT. THE BEAR/KITCHEN

Fak looks around, surveying if any customers need help.

A man wearing a trench coat, with a hat and a pair of glasses walks in. Fak instantly spots him, and looks around for someone to greet him, but no one is there.

FAK

(to himself)

Oh my god, he's here. And it's just me.

Fak slowly walks up to the front.

FAK (CONT'D)

Good afternoon, my good sir! We've been eagerly expecting your presence. Please come this way.

He leads the man to a table. Meanwhile, Richie walks out of the kitchen, and up to the front as another guest walks in.

JASON PLUMLEE (young, tall, muscles, style - whole package) is greeted by Richie like a friend.

RICHIE

Good to see you Jason, let me show to your table.

Richie leads, and Jason follows.

INT. THE BEAR/KITCHEN - SAME TIME

Sydney stands at the front, and starts rifling off orders.

SYDNEY
TWO STEAK, TWO CHICKEN, ONE GARLIC
BREAD APP!

EVERYONE
HEARD!

Everyone is in the zone as the kitchen moves slowly, and Sydney works to keep herself in a flow state.

Tina gets close to her, and starts whispering.

TINA
You see who just came in?

SYDNEY
No. Why?

TINA
Take a look.

Sydney takes a quick glance behind her, but doesn't give it much thought.

TINA (CONT'D)
He's cute, right?

SYDNEY
What? I guess, he's fine. What does it matter Tina, I'm trying to get this right for the critic.

TINA
That *is* the critic.

SYDNEY
That's the critic?

Tina raises her eyebrows like, "YUP".

TINA
You're blushing a little, admit it.

SYDNEY
I'll admit it if you go fire me
three new steaks.

Tina smiles, accomplished, and walks away.

Sydney takes one more look outside, and gets back to work.